night wondering how we could rescue the hostages, trying to sleep while images of those lonely Americans rolled past in my mind. In May 1985, another face joined the images in this nightly newsreel; David P. Jacobsen, an administrator at the American University in Beirut, became the seventh American hostage held in Lebanon.

As president, as far as I was concerned, I had the duty to get those Americans home.

Almost every morning at my national security briefings, I began by asking the same question: “Any progress on getting the hostages out of Lebanon?”

I still believed that the key to achieving a permanent peace in the Middle East and ending the strife that had led to the taking of the hostages was to get other moderate Arab countries, in addition to Egypt, to help us work out an agreement that provided for the acceptance of Israel’s right to exist together with a land-for-peace concession that gave territory and autonomy to the Palestinians. The problems wouldn’t go away until we solved the problems of the Palestinians and until the security of Israel was ensured with adequate safeguards.

I was determined to build more bridges to the moderate Arab countries, and emphasized this during separate state visits by King Fahd of Saudi Arabia, President Hosni Mubarak of Egypt, and King Hussein of Jordan during the spring of 1985. All of them promised help in the search for peace in the Middle East. In return, all wanted U.S. weapons and what they considered a more even-handed U.S. policy in the Middle East.

Understandably, Saudi Arabia was vitally concerned about the security of its oil resources. King Hussein, who had been courageous in trying to persuade his Arab neighbors to come to terms with the reality of Israel, told me that, because of antipathy over his efforts to bring about peace, he felt threatened by Syria and its Soviet-equipped army.